The Frankfurt School

The Frankfurt School is one of the most important currents in twentieth-century German thought. It extends nineteenth-century German speculative philosophy, drawing especially on Marx but also on much of the continental tradition. Its intellectual project is inseparable from Germany's political catastrophes: defeat in the First World War in 1918 and the Treaty of Versailles in 1919, Hitler's accession to power in 1933, and the defeat and Allied occupation of Germany in 1945.

During the Weimar Republic the political centre weakened, and the polarisation between the fascist right and the communist or Marxist left was much sharper than anything familiar in the United States. For intellectuals opposed to National Socialism, taking a position on the left was understandable. But it is difficult to move directly from that history to American society and politics. The differences are sometimes lost on members of the Frankfurt School. Their interpretation makes more sense if one remembers the polarisation in which it arose and the catastrophe brought about by the other side.

The school brings different disciplines together in a critique of society. "Critique" has a Kantian sense here: it establishes limits and is normative as well as conceptual. Its members and associates include the psychoanalyst Erich Fromm, the historian Karl August Wittfogel, the music theorist Theodor W. Adorno and the political thinker Herbert Marcuse. They look at the wreckage of Berlin and German culture somewhat as Thomas Mann does in *Doctor Faustus*. The catastrophe was not simply imposed from outside. Something had gone terribly wrong within the culture. They ask where the West as a whole, rather than Germany alone, went wrong.

Their undertaking has three parts. They try to explain contemporary society, to trace the origins of its crisis and to say what ought to happen next. Like Marx, they want to break down the separation of theory from practice. Philosophers have interpreted the world, but the point is to change it. A theory should show how things went wrong, how they might be put right and why we ought to put them right. It issues imperatives as well as statements. Its conception of reason is normative and teleological.

Kantian ethics, for example, seeks to derive universal moral laws from pure reason. In the contrasting tradition represented by Hume, reason is the slave of the passions. It can identify means to ends but cannot choose the ends for us. The German tradition maintains that reason can also tell us what ends we ought to pursue. It thus extends reason beyond science and mathematics into ethics and, with Adorno, into aesthetics. Like Hegel's project, this is ambitious enough to deserve a charitable hearing even if it cannot fulfil its aims.

Consider the position associated here with Marcuse, Horkheimer and Adorno. It treats fascism and Nazism as totalitarian developments made possible by capitalist society. On a Marxist account, economic base, social structure and ideological superstructure are intertwined. The emergence of fascism in societies at a similar stage of economic development suggests, on the strong version of this argument, that totalitarianism and its accompanying genocide are consequences of the destruction of reason under capitalism. Responsibility is laid at the door of the upper bourgeoisie, and the

catastrophe seems to make a case for proletarian revolution. Against the background of German polarisation, the theorists fear that rejecting the Marxist alternative means yielding to the right. They seek a way to escape ideological illusions and attain a rational understanding that tells us both what the world is and how we should act in it.

Capitalist ideology, in this account, reduces reason to instrumental reason. It is closer to Hume's conception of reason than to Kant's. The Anglo-American tradition, and the positivism with which the school associates it, describe the world as what is the case. Reason can tell us how things are, but cannot derive what ought to be from observations, science or mathematics. The logical positivists of the Vienna Circle thus exemplify, for the Frankfurt School, a conception of knowledge that deprives judgments about right and wrong of rational standing. The argument is that this opens Pandora's box. Opposition to nihilism or Nazism would be a matter of taste rather than of reason. In the school's account, that intellectual situation helps prepare the ground for totalitarianism. It is a striking argument and may have something to it.

Positivism is only one expression of this limited idea of reason. Neoclassical economics explains how markets work without saying how they ought to work. Political liberalism allows you to hold one opinion and me another without settling which opinion is right. What these approaches and logical positivism have in common, on this reading, is *technē* without *telos*: they tell us how to do things without telling us which ends to pursue. It is surprising to find such an affinity between logical positivism and neoclassical economics. What unites them is their exclusion of the "ought" from reason's domain. The school fears that this leaves the door open to nihilists, fascists and bigots.

The Frankfurt School draws selectively on the history of philosophy. From Rousseau it takes a sense of lost innocence. In *The Social Contract*, human beings are born free and find themselves everywhere in chains. Here the chains are those of ideology. Socialisation in late capitalism imposes categories and habits of thought that distort our understanding of the world and have political consequences.

From Kant it takes moral universality and the idea that reason can tell us what we ought to do. From Hegel it takes historicism and the idea of progress as the realisation of freedom. Kant's conception of autonomy links freedom, rationality and morality, and Hegel inherits that connection. From the left-wing reading of Hegel taken up by Marx it takes *praxis* and political commitment. A true theory of the world should move people to act. Passively understanding the world is less than half the work of philosophy. There is something attractive in that idea.

Marxism alone leaves a gap. Marx seldom describes the individual psyche or its relation to society except in terms of the pressure of production and ideology. The Frankfurt School reads Freud closely and combines his psychology with a Marxian philosophy of history. The two are complementary: Marx offers a social and historical account, while Freud gives a way to think about how society and the individual psyche shape each other.

Heidegger is another influence. Herbert Marcuse studied with him in Freiburg after completing his doctorate and considered pursuing a habilitation under him. Heidegger's commitment to Nazism came as a profound disappointment. How could a thinker of his ability give the Nazi salute? What had happened to philosophy that this was possible? Yet Heidegger's influence can still be felt in Marcuse and the school. One aspect is what

I would call technophobia. In *The Question Concerning Technology*, technology is associated with a form of alienation, and I find this tendency to distrust science and especially technology regrettable.

Another aspect is hostility to mass culture and to the anonymous mass individual. Despite its appeals to universality, participatory democracy and liberation, the Frankfurt School can seem strikingly elitist. Its thought is hard to enter without specialised training. The student revolts of the 1960s took up a more accessible version of it. In the school's view, people in developed democracies have been induced to misunderstand their world. The philosopher is meant to help them out of the fly-bottle, out of their own ideology.

In this respect the school belongs alongside Georg Lukács, especially his *History and Class Consciousness*, and the early work of Antonio Gramsci. These are attempts, especially in the wake of the First World War and the Bolshevik Revolution, to turn from what they take to be the positivist Marx of *Capital* and the *Grundrisse* to the earlier, Hegelian Marx. The focus is on freedom, alienation and emancipation from socially imposed limits on thought.

The central idea is that freedom is reason. "The truth shall make you free" becomes a philosophical proposition in much the way that Hegel translates a pictorial representation into a conceptual one. Rationality has substantive content, and is not merely formal. Here the conflict with the Vienna Circle comes to a head. The positivists' pursuit of logical formalisation, and the wider programme of reducing mathematics to logic, run into limits exemplified by Gödel's incompleteness theorems. For the Frankfurt School the deeper mistake is to treat reason as merely formal. Its objection resembles the one Kant would raise against Hume: a truncated reason cannot investigate ends and only reflects the assumptions of the society in which it operates. In the terms suggested by the historian Leonard Krieger, this is a twentieth-century version of the German idea of freedom. Freedom means breaking the grip of the illusions a society has imposed on us, rather than merely being able to do what we want.

Herbert Marcuse was probably the best-known member of the school. He left Germany for the United States and was unhappy with what he found. Like any other late capitalist society, America lived, in his view, under a veil of *maya*, or illusion. A society divided into classes produced false consciousness, and without a proletarian revolution there was no reason to expect it to disappear. Marcuse therefore criticised both twentieth-century European politics and the United States. I think the school was less successful at explaining the latter. It claimed universality, but there is a saying that a person is never so provincial as when he begins to legislate for the universe. These theorists spend a great deal of time legislating for a universe that, in practice, seems to consist of a few people who understand their project.

One of Marcuse's first important books, *Reason and Revolution*, revives left-wing Hegelianism. It continues the kind of history of philosophy and speculative psychology found in Hegel's *Phenomenology*. How did positivism and scientism come to prevail in the late nineteenth century, and what were their twentieth-century consequences? This is a worthwhile question. *Eros and Civilization*, which became popular among student radicals in the 1960s, combines Freud and Marx and takes up Freud's account of the individual and society without accepting his pessimism.

In *Civilization and Its Discontents*, Freud argues that the conflict between individual and society cannot be resolved altogether. Civilised life requires the frustration of some desires. Sexual conduct is subject to limits, including prohibitions on incest, and people cannot kill anyone who gets on their nerves. Marcuse does not propose abolishing every constraint. He argues that many restrictions on emotional life and the libido serve social domination rather than civilisation itself. Once the veil of illusion lifts, archaic sexual conventions could lose their hold and a much less repressive life become possible. In the lecture's reading, this promises a sexual utopia and recalls Freud's notion of polymorphous sexuality.

I find Freud more persuasive here. One thought suggested by *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* is that limits matter to pleasure itself, as well as to social order. Without contrast, being able to do everything may lead to despair. A second thought, which I would take from Kierkegaard, is that giving the id and the libido constant expression would be terribly boring. Think of the Marquis de Sade. Does he look happy for having given his libido free rein? I am not convinced there is happiness at the end of this yellow brick road. It may lead instead to what Durkheim called anomie, the breakdown of norms, and hence to nihilism and despair.

In *Soviet Marxism*, Marcuse rejected the Soviet model as falling short of what he took to be genuinely humanistic Marxism. This can sound self-indulgent, but it is hard to see a practical alternative within the polarised framework he inherits. He asks us to work towards a different society without showing exactly how we can get there from a technologically organised, hierarchical and repressive state.

Marcuse's most influential book is *One-Dimensional Man*. There is something incongruous about this dour German academic outlook in sunny Southern California. It is like Oedipus in Disneyland. Imagine telling young Americans who surf, have sex, drink beer and listen to rock and roll that their happiness is illusory. In Marcuse's argument, they take up fashionable forms of culture and think themselves free under liberal democracy, but they remain alienated and fail to attain their *telos*. New York, with its European connections, was an easier cultural transition for these émigrés. California sharpened the contrast, for Adorno as well as Marcuse.

In *One-Dimensional Man*, scientism, neoclassical economics and liberal politics make teleological criticism impossible. Judgments of ends and of right and wrong become matters of opinion. Technological rationality and linguistic philosophy share in this narrowing, and *Herrschaft*, or domination, can then present itself as necessary and escape questioning. The book tries to break that mould by applying German teleological reason to Americans who, for the most part, did not want to hear about it.

It became a touchstone for student radicals in the United States and in France, especially around 1968. Many readers were drawn to its refusal to take the goodness of their society for granted, even if they found its argument difficult. Watching footage of the Columbia protests of 1968, I am not inclined to call what I see the summit of rationality. Perhaps it is teleological reason. On the whole, the approach is more persuasive about the rise of Nazism and fascism in Europe than it is as an account of American society.

Theodor W. Adorno is in some respects the inverse of Marcuse. Less systematic and more indebted to Nietzsche, he is above all a thinker about art. His music essays can be

lovely, as in *Bach Defended Against His Devotees*. The difficulty is that his hostility to the world as it is comes with an elusive account of how to change it and what to change it into. With Max Horkheimer he wrote *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, which examines how Enlightenment reason can turn into domination and how the culture industry belongs to that development.

Adorno detested much mass music, notably jazz and popular music, and prized twelve-tone composition. On the satirical account that follows from his view, listening to Elvis Presley instead of twelve-tone music marks us as alienated and as people who understand nothing about music. Adorno can be very dogmatic. The difficulty of making judgments in aesthetics precise can give dogmatism free rein.

The Authoritarian Personality offers a different example of the combination of Marx and Freud. The study, published in 1950, was written by Adorno, Else Frenkel-Brunswik, Daniel J. Levinson and R. Nevitt Sanford. It was conducted in the United States. Its question was how people could become receptive to fascism and antisemitism, in light of what had happened in Germany. Might a society socialise people in ways that systematically distort their capacities for moral judgment? How could one identify such a personality and imagine a different kind of socialisation?

What is remarkable for this school is the use of empirical evidence. The researchers used attitude questionnaires and interviews to construct a model of the potentially authoritarian personality. Its traits include rigid conformity, hostility to people outside the accepted norm, antisemitism and xenophobia. The psychoanalytic interpretation also associates it with submissive and aggressive, or sadomasochistic, tendencies. The study concerns susceptibility to authoritarianism, not the existence of an overt authoritarian regime in the United States.

The critical move I object to is to treat conformity in America as proof of authoritarianism in disguise. On that view rock and roll, films and surfboards are a veil of illusion, a velvet glove on an iron hand. American liberal society becomes authoritarianism with a smiling face. The danger is that the categories of late capitalism and truncated reason make liberal America and Nazi Germany look alike despite their political differences. Whether a country has an authoritarian government or not, the theorist can claim to find authoritarian personalities.

I suspect you could find conformist personalities in post-war Russia, Sweden, Turkey, Angola or even at the South Pole. Does the term end up meaning anyone who is not a member of the Frankfurt School? There is another possibility. Give people considerable freedom and much of what they do is imitate one another. Go to a shop and see everyone buy the same fashion. Nobody holds a gun to their head. They like to resemble others and feel more comfortable doing so. That may be a feature of the human condition rather than a disease. Adorno is at his best, to my mind, in *Minima Moralia*, a book of Nietzschean aphorisms about an extraordinary range of things. It is an engaging and relatively approachable way into his work.

The last of the three figures is Max Horkheimer. *Eclipse of Reason*, based in part on lectures at Columbia University, offers a good introduction to the Frankfurt School. The title *Critique of Instrumental Reason* brings its concern into focus. Instrumental reason discloses means, never ends. It is Humean reason. One can trace this strand of thought from Bacon to Hume and on to logical positivism. It tells us how to achieve our ends but

not what ends to pursue. Horkheimer's title recalls Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason*. Horkheimer asks what happens when rationality is restricted to instrumentality, and he connects the restriction with political and economic misery in the twentieth century.

What came of the Frankfurt School? One important outcome is the work of Jürgen Habermas, a second-generation figure and, in my view, one of the most important social theorists. He is almost as difficult to read as his predecessors, but far less dogmatic and more willing to engage fairly with Anglo-American thought. He tries to absorb what it has to offer, in a Hegelian spirit, rather than dismissing it. To have provided a starting point for Habermas is one of the school's great achievements.

A second outcome, in my reading, is the influence of critical theory on Critical Legal Studies in the United States. Critical Legal Studies challenges the bourgeois assumptions and instrumental view of reason it finds in black-letter law. It attempts to uncover the biases and conceptual distortions built into legal doctrine and its place in a repressive social structure. The results do not impress me as much as the undertaking, but the intellectual kinship with the Frankfurt School is clear.

A third consequence concerns what came to be called political correctness. Marcuse's "Repressive Tolerance" appeared in *A Critique of Pure Tolerance*, a volume with Robert Paul Wolff and Barrington Moore Jr. Marcuse argues that apparently neutral tolerance can entrench existing power and thus restrict effective freedom of expression. He proposes a form of liberating tolerance that treats dominant and suppressed views differently. The paradox, as I see it, is that what we call free speech is treated as covert censorship, while restricting some speech is treated as the way to freedom. If professors end up deciding what may be said, the outcome is not attractive. In my view, the popularised form of this idea is political correctness, the school's least welcome legacy.

The Frankfurt School also shows how the social sciences became a battleground for philosophical disagreements in the twentieth century. Consider the contrast between the structuralist anthropology of Claude Lévi-Strauss and the functionalist anthropology of Bronisław Malinowski. The former stands here for a continental approach and the latter for an empirical approach associated with the Anglo-American tradition. In this reading, the disagreement recapitulates the conflict between Hume and Kant. Similar disputes arise in sociology, political science and political theory.

Carl Hempel's covering-law account of historical explanation illustrates the attempt to bring history and the social sciences closer to the model of physics. Against that wider background, Adorno confronted Karl Popper in what became known as the *Positivismusstreit*, the positivism dispute in German sociology. Popper was a critical rationalist rather than a member of the Vienna Circle. The question was whether a method modelled on the natural sciences is adequate for understanding human beings and societies. For Adorno, a method that ignores the ends and norms at work in human affairs risks collapsing culture into nature. The distinction between nature and spirit has a long history, with echoes of Cartesian dualism. The exchange over method produced a great deal of ink and sharp argument. The subject matter had changed, but one can still hear an older argument between Hume and Kant.

There is a real danger in assuming that right and wrong lie entirely outside the bounds of knowledge. The logical tidiness of positivism makes the assumption tempting, but it can be costly. So I would give two cheers for the Frankfurt School. It tries to offer a way

out of the labyrinth of modernity, a way of thinking about a world that is more than a desert of objects.

My first objection is that treating fascism as the final stage of capitalism can lead one either to ignore liberal democracy or to conflate it with fascism. Compare Nazi Germany with the United States. In my judgment, the differences matter more than the similarities. If the school wants to maintain a connection and show that advanced capitalism necessarily leaves Americans in a realm of illusion, it has to establish that claim. Much of what passes for a universal analysis seems to me a European criticism transplanted to America, where it works badly. Its aspiration to universality turns out to be remarkably provincial.

My second objection is arbitrary dogmatism. This is not especially true of Habermas, who resists dogmatic thinking, but Adorno's essays on jazz offer a striking example. Adorno brings together Marx and Freud to interpret jazz as an ideological form and gives castration anxiety a central place in his reading of it. How does he establish such a conclusion? Think of Charlie Parker, John Coltrane and Miles Davis. What does this account explain about their music or about the lives of jazz musicians? If it were a meal, I would send it back. An appreciation of different cultures is an advantage here. This is more than Eurocentrism. It is Adorno-centrism. The harder the theory tries to be universal, the more provincial it becomes.

One last interpretation draws on the idea of the German mandarins, a humanistic intellectual elite that no longer has an obvious social role. The physicist and the mathematician still do things that people consider useful. The mandarins are less often consulted, and they do not like it. On this reading, they construct a quasi-theology that tells us how benighted we are for listening to rock and roll rather than twelve-tone music, or watching television rather than Brecht's plays. The theorists assume a quasi-messianic role: they will lead us out of bondage to ideology and towards a freedom guided by reason.

My suggestion is that a coalition of labour, capital and technology emerged and left the old humanistic elite outside it. The coalition generated a mass culture that this elite despised. The intellectuals needed a way to tell others that they misunderstood the world and needed instruction. In the United States one can read Critical Legal Studies, controversially, as another version of this reaction. Both become, on my account, a way for the mandarins to have their revenge.

It would be too simple to say that this is merely a lust for power, which in Kantian terms would be heteronomous. Plato's guardians rule the *Republic* because they believe they have a moral obligation and an understanding of the ends society should pursue. Something like that belief is at work here. On this final, deliberately polemical reading, the Frankfurt School again tells us that philosophers must become kings. The claim rests on the conviction that autonomous reason requires rule by an intellectual elite, an elite that, in my view, is steeped in Gnostic resentment.